

While you can use HTML code editors and WYSIWYG editors to build your HTML pages, it is recommended that you start off with hand coding to get an in-depth understanding of the way HTML works. Once you're fairly confident of your HTML skills, you can then go ahead to use advanced editing tools. HTML only requires a simple text editor to start coding. Do take the time to work through the sample code included in this section to get a hands-on feel on working with HTML.

2.1 Basic Formatting Using HTML

An HTML file contains “markup tags” that tell the Web browser how to follow the instructions enclosed within the tags. The angular brackets “<” and “>” indicate that the text within the brackets is a tag. The start of the tag and the end of the tag are identified using special formats. For example, <p> indicates the start of a new paragraph, and </p> indicates the end of the paragraph. Regular text, or other instructions depending on the tag type, is enclosed between the starting and ending tags. Tags are not case sensitive, that is, <p> and <P> mean the same thing.

Each tag can have attributes. These provide additional formatting and other information regarding the tag. For example, the <body> tag can have an attribute to specify the background colour of the Web page. <body bgcolor=“blue”> will render the Web page with a blue background.

Every HTML document starts with the <html> tag indicating to the Web browser the start of the HTML document, and ends with the </html> tag, which indicates the end of the document. A basic HTML document looks like this:

```
<html>
<head>
<title>My first HTML page</title>
</head>
```